

Defender Sheet

Bridge Habit Map

DEFENSE PLAN

Discipline

- ☐ Don't rush, don't get rushed — especially trick 1
- ☐ Have a reason for what you do

Count the points

- ☐ Add declarer + dummy HCP, subtract from 40
- ☐ Divide missing points using the auction
- ☐ If dummy is strong, give declarer minimum for their bid

Picture the unseen hands

- ☐ Build a hand-pattern for declarer (e.g. 3-5-3-2)
- ☐ Memorise your hand + dummy before playing

Count declarer's tricks

- ☐ Count declarer's distribution, HCP, and tricks
- ☐ No side-suit tricks for you? Look to trump (overruff, uppercut, promotion)

Identify the winning defense

- ☐ Which 2–3 declarer hand-patterns let you beat the contract?
- ☐ What suit does declarer fear?

Active or passive (binary)

- ☐ Long-suit declarer with a source of tricks → ACTIVE
- ☐ Balanced declarer, no obvious source → PASSIVE (don't break suits)
- ☐ Don't grab aces prematurely — aces capture kings

Opening lead (if on lead)

- ☐ Determine if lead should be passive or aggressive
- ☐ Avoid suits opponents bid; favour unbid suits
- ☐ vs NT: 4th best from longest, or top of sequence
- ☐ vs suit: K from AK, top of doubleton; don't underlead an ace

- ☐ Trump lead if auction suggests a cross-ruff; not vs misfit
- ☐ Lead partner's bid suit unless you have a clear reason not to

Watch & remember

- ☐ Commit the first few cards from partner + declarer to memory
- ☐ Decide now which spot cards in which suits will matter

Defensive evaluation

- ☐ REAP — Zia update
- ☐ In competitive auctions, weigh partner's bids — especially the no-bids
- ☐ At trick 1, fix declarer's and partner's points and shape

Defensive play

- ☐ Changing suit: high discourages, low encourages the same-suit return
- ☐ Partner's discouraging opening lead → think about where his values are

Leads

- ☐ Lead a trump if opps are playing in their second suit (cut dummy's ruffs)
- ☐ Lead the ace of our suit if you have it — don't underlead it
- ☐ Don't lead trumps on a misfit unless it reduces ruffing

Signals & declarer set-ups

- ☐ Give and look for all defensive signals
- ☐ When signalling, don't make dummy's cards high
- ☐ Don't make dummy high or give declarer discards — if you must, take your tricks
- ☐ Careful cashing winners at the end unless you know you won't set up declarer
- ☐ Always reduce dummy's trumps if a short-suit ruff is possible